

Back to “Back to Labor”: Revisiting Political Economies of Computer-Supported Cooperative Work

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ABSTRACT

Almost thirty years ago, CSCW published an article written by Joan Greenbaum detailing how and why CSCW should consider the framing of “labor” over “work” in researching and designing information systems [17]. This argument is especially salient in the present day, with the increasing wariness of algorithmically-mediated monitoring, surveillance, automation, and management in work processes. Despite its salience, Greenbaum’s paper has had relatively low engagement in CSCW so far. As such, this workshop responds to Greenbaum’s call-to-action, asking: 1) Where is CSCW research now in thinking about “work” vs. “labor” in designing systems? and 2) How can we support emerging CSCW scholars in grounding themselves in theories of work that includes—if not centers—a labor-oriented economic frame? Following a Freirean pedagogy model of social action involving a cycle of reflection and action, this workshop will aim to generate a critical consciousness around labor issues in CSCW. Ultimately, by crafting individual commitments to labor, this workshop will aim to contribute to a more worker-centered future.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Computer supported cooperative work.**

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KEYWORDS

labor, work, future of work, workplace accountability, worker-centered design

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1 INTRODUCTION

As new scholars enter the field of Computer-Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW), we do so during a time of heightened labor consciousness and tech wariness. Inspired by CSCW scholar Joan Greenbaum’s argument that “labor is more than work,” this workshop aims to mobilize past, present, and future researchers of CSCW in (re-)orienting ourselves to a grounding of *work* that adequately accounts for *labor*. Revisiting Greenbaum at this crucial political moment we ask: Where is CSCW research now in thinking about “work” vs. “labor” in designing systems? How can we support emerging CSCW scholars in grounding themselves in theories of work that includes—if not centers—a labor-oriented economic frame?

In defining the political significance of this current moment we look to tech workers [2, 20, 39], Amazon factory workers [3], and Starbucks baristas [35] who are holding union drives at rates that would have seemed impossible just a decade ago. Most recently, the Writer’s Guild of America has also gone on strike aiming, at least in part, to regulate the use of generative AI systems in their workplace [40]. Similarly, content moderators who train the toxicity

filters for OpenAI's ChatGPT have unionized in an effort to receive just compensation for the psychologically damaging jobs they are tasked with [32].

These movements signify that workplace technologies (regarding monitoring, surveillance, automation, or algorithmic management) largely favors the managerial classes, and that adopting and building new technology without worker agency creates precarious and harmful working conditions by shifting power away from the workers [4, 16, 18, 26, 34, 36].

With this workshop, we hope to discuss with CSCW scholars about the benefits and consequences of work technologies, and our roles in contributing to the broader cultures around them. We hope to engage with emerging scholars specifically, as their attitudes tell us about the present and future of the field; their understandings outline what is being taught, and what work is being done. As emerging scholars and faculty collaborators, we understand how challenging it can be to think about the future of work in its totality, and we hope this workshop can help scholars of all backgrounds consider the consequences of workplace and work-mediating technologies more deeply.

1.1 Labor Vs. Work: A Preliminary Review of Greenbaum's Legacy in CSCW

In 1996, Joan Greenbaum published a CSCW paper, "Back to Labor: Returning to labor process discussions in the study of work." In the paper, Greenbaum argues that the focus on "work" in CSCW should be expanded to consider a labor process perspective and "the role of labor issues such as wages, working conditions and division of labor in analyzing the consequences of information system design" [17, p.229]. Given its relevance to contemporary labor struggle and developing conversations in CSCW, we were surprised to see low engagement with the paper: as of May 2023, it shows 35 citations on Google Scholar. As such, almost thirty years after "Back to Labor" was published, we hope to use this workshop to understand how CSCW has (intentionally or unintentionally) responded to Greenbaum's call-to-action for broader engagements with labor processes in designing and studying systems.

Although not a normative discourse, research in CSCW-adjacent venues have more broadly with political and economic ramifications of work in recent years. For example, given the unique sociotechnical orientation of platform-mediated labor, computing research has explored topics such as worker invisibility [8, 21, 38], worker organizing [5, 23], unfair labor practices [19, 27], and more broadly, worker-centered design and its related challenges [1, 6, 10, 22, 37]. Beyond platform-mediated labor, CSCW and its counterparts have engaged with topics such as workplace accountability [9, 24], algorithmic integration and management [11, 33], and worker surveillance [29, 30], amongst others. Just last year, the Labor Tech Research Network, "an interdisciplinary group of experts in labor, technology, anti-racism, feminism, and transnationalism," formally launched at the 2022 4S Conference [25].

The normative discourse on work technologies remains largely detached from the sub-culture of labor-engaged research. For example, we might analyze the discourse of the NSF "Future of Work at the Human-Technology Frontier" grant description to surface norms around work technologies in the U.S. [31]. We use this as a

touchpoint to roughly understand the foci of the CSCW community because it is frequently a funding target for CSCW research in the U.S, and—as discussed by Tandon et al. [37]—grant restrictions and expectations can greatly influence what kinds of research are done. In this grant description, only one of the five stated points of focus discusses both risks *and* benefits of technologies; the other points focus on development, design, influencing impact, and learning, all of which arguably pose a certain technological future as inevitable, if not solely beneficial. We may put this in conversation with Greenbaum's discussion of how technologically-intensified labor processes in the U.S. ultimately led to losses in wages, working conditions, and job security in the 1990s, despite promises of worker satisfaction as an outcome of task integration and upskilling in the 1980s [17]. In the current day, we look to how AI technologies may be incorporated into the workplace with the logic of increased creativity. However, a labor-oriented economic framing would interrogate this trend by asking: What happens when executives see ChatGPT's assistance as an opportunity to save labor costs [40]?

In our own work as emerging scholars, we follow the non-normative route in paying a special attention to labor-oriented economic frames. Our specific projects include looking at WTO protest archives and technologies to analyze discourses of globalization and solidarity for global and local workers, critical consciousness-based organizing strategies for data workers, examining the role of algorithmic decision-making in 2023 tech layoffs, and interrogating institutions and policies that are critical to the existence of technology.

2 WORKSHOP GOALS, THEMES, AND ACTIVITIES

Our goal for this workshop is to develop community networks for understanding and navigating the complex relationships between technology design and labor with CSCW scholars who have various levels of experience with broader labor framings in their research. The workshop will be a combination of a virtual grounding event followed by a one-day, in-person gathering at CSCW 2023.

Inspired by Ghoshal et al. [15], this workshop follows a Freirean pedagogy model of social action involving a cycle of reflection and action [13], or as commonly exercised in Peoples Movement Assemblies, a cycle of consciousness and commitment [12, 14]. While the goal of the first half of the workshop is to generate a shared consciousness of the ways that CSCW approaches questions of labor (reflection), the goal of the second half of the workshop is to find ways we can commit to critically engaging with the politics and material realities of labor (action).

2.1 Planned Activities: Online

2.1.1 Grounding: A Labor Roundtable. Following Lyon et al. [28], we propose a synchronous virtual event approximately one week before the workshop for participants to ground their thinking in the themes of the workshop and familiarize with each other's work. We will begin with brief introductions of the organizers and the workshop background and goals, including a presentation outlining key takeaways from Greenbaum's 1996 paper.

Then, up to twelve participants will be invited to give short (max 10 minute) presentations on their work to their peers. This

activity will allow emerging scholars to discuss ideas or research that may become full papers later on, find shared areas of interest and inquiry, and understand how their peers are currently thinking about labor-related topics.

2.2 Planned Activities: In-Person

2.2.1 Session I: Community-Building Exercise. We will kick-off the in-person gathering with a community-building exercise. The exercise will focus on generating a shared consciousness of what it means to consider labor alongside work. Drawing from the Tech Worker’s Coalition [39] and our experiences with union organizing as graduate students, this activity will encourage participants to reflect on their relationships with work and labor.

After situating ourselves in our personal/work histories, we will encourage participants to share concerns, fears, and hopes for the workshop, as well as specific community agreements that would make them feel comfortable sharing vulnerabilities, challenging understandings, and giving/receiving feedback.

2.2.2 Session II: Discussion on Current and Future Strategies. Next, we will arrange participants into small groups. Each group will have a facilitator who will take notes, summarize discussion, and later report back to the larger group for a broader discussion. Discussions will focus on three topics which are intended to foster critical reflections on the role of CSCW and work technologies in a broader labor context: *disciplinary norms, accountability and relationality, and future(s)*.

- **Disciplinary norms:** As this workshop somewhat serves as a retrospective to Greenbaum’s call-to-action in 1996 [17], we shall ground our discussions in the disciplinary norms and design agendas that participants have noticed in the field: *What kinds of work or labor framings have you noticed or interacted with in existing CSCW literature? How do CSCW findings get operationalized in these papers? What do you see as CSCW’s goal or theory of change with respect to labor? What do you see as the role of CSCW research in context of work and labor relations today?*
- **Accountability and relationality:** Further interacting with Greenbaum’s suggestion for accountability in design [17, p.233] and recent conversations around accountability in the future of work in CSCW [9, 10], we will prompt participants to reflect on who or what their research should be accountable to: *Who does your research benefit, and how? How does your work interact with labor relations moving forward? How do you relate to the people who will use the technologies you’re designing? What is the theory of change of your work? What does it mean for us to be accountable for the (positive or negative) consequences of the technologies we design?*
- **Future(s):** Lastly, we hope to encourage participants to consider the sociotechnical contexts and consequences of their work. We will prompt participants to reflect on the relationships and futures that their work prioritizes: *What kind of future does your work strive toward or take for granted? What is your role in the world you want to see? How might this world be similar to / different from the futures or outcomes of the theories of change that are represented by your work (or the work you’ve seen so far)?*

2.2.3 Session III: Synthesis and Future Steps. Finally, the full group will reflect on the entire day and establish future steps. Inspired by grassroots tradition [15], we will ask each attendee for a *commitment to action*. In this session, we will plan how to advance these commitments in the CSCW community, which may include brainstorming possible future events, submitting a workshop retrospective to a venue like *ACM Interactions*, and personal commitments to act on reflections from this workshop in our future work.

3 OUTCOMES

3.1 Solidarity network for emerging labor-engaged CSCW scholars

One of our expected outcomes is to establish an online workspace that can better enable emerging labor-engaged scholars to build community with each other. This workspace will encourage participants to keep in touch, share work, receive feedback from peers, and collaborate. Community moderation will be led by the student organizers of this workshop. Community guidelines of the workspace will be based on the code of conduct for the CSCW 2022 Discord [7], then extended with the community agreements established during the workshop. Our goal is to foster peer mentorship and support networks for junior scholars in CSCW, specifically in committing to a broader framing of work and labor in their research.

3.2 Mapping current understandings of work and labor in CSCW

We further hope to develop an understanding of how CSCW scholars think about the relationship and distinction between work and labor. Findings (developed from notes taken by the organizers and artifacts from the workshop) will be written up as a short article that will be submitted to a venue like *ACM Interactions* or posted online as a blog post.

3.3 Informal Labor and/in CSCW syllabus

Lastly, an outcome of the workshop will be an informal *Labor and/in CSCW* syllabus that is co-created by workshop participants and organizers. At the end of each workshop, we will ask participants and organizers to share any readings that have influenced their thinking with regard to work and labor. Then, the organizing team will arrange recommendations into an informal syllabus that can support for scholars with varying levels of knowledge around framings of labor. The syllabus will be posted on the workshop website after CSCW 2023. Our goal is to have an accessible, structured database of influential papers for CSCW scholars who would like resources to broaden their understandings of work and labor.

4 LOGISTICS

4.1 Asynchronous Engagement

Prior to recruitment, we will create a public website describing the goals, themes, and activities of the workshop, as well as a call for participation. Later, the website will also host accepted paper submissions and the informal *Labor and/in CSCW* syllabus.

We will also create a private Slack or Discord workspace prior to the virtual workshop. This will allow us to facilitate conversation between online and in-person participants. After the workshop, the

workspace will serve as the lasting site for the peer network for emerging scholars.

4.2 Recruiting and selecting participants

We will recruit CSCW scholars with research interests in the future of work and labor, including but not limited to topics such as platform-mediated labor, workplace technologies, and technical workplace dynamics. We will promote the website (with the call for participation) via social media, mailing lists, and the organizers' professional networks. We will primarily direct recruitment toward 1) early-career graduate students and their collaborators and 2) senior scholars wanting to broaden or bridge conversations in CSCW about work and labor. The call for participation will ask prospective participants to submit a 500-word reflection on their personal and academic orientations to work and/vs. labor, as well as their current or aspirational connections to labor-related research. Prospective participants will also have an option to submit a short workshop paper if they would like to share and discuss works in progress in the virtual grounding event. We anticipate 20-25 participants for the in-person event.

4.3 Facilitators

The authors of this proposal will facilitate both the in-person and online workshop sessions.

4.4 Equipment and supplies needed

Supplies needed for the in-person workshop will be a projector, post-it notes, markers, and large easel pads. Facilitators will use personal laptops for note taking during small group discussions. The online workshop event will be hosted on the first author's institutional Zoom account.

5 ORGANIZERS

Joice Tang

Joice Tang is a first year PhD student in HCDE at UW. Her current work draws on WTO protest archives and theories of social ecology to analyze discourses of cooperation in CSCW. In undergrad, her work focused on perceptions of technological impact in education and platform-mediated labor contexts. She is an active organizer with UAW 4121.

McKane Andrus

McKane Andrus is a first year PhD student in HCDE at UW. Their current work explores raising critical consciousness around datafication and targeting it as a site for reclaiming power. Their prior work at the Partnership on AI unpacked personal and organizational tensions that arise for tech workers when trying to implement algorithmic fairness interventions.

Samuel So

Samuel So is a second year PhD student in HCDE at UW. His work examines digital traces and personal data, with a recent focus on worker-led sensemaking around workplace data and its consequences on managerial decision-making processes. He is currently

investigating workplace accountability surrounding the 2023 Tech Layoffs with Professors Ghoshal and Munson.

Udayan Tandon

Udayan Tandon is a fourth year PhD student at the Just Transitions Initiative in the Design Lab at the University of California San Diego (UCSD). He has been working alongside United Taxi Workers of San Diego for over three years, supporting them in operationalizing their vision of a publicly supported and regulated on-demand transportation alternative in San Diego [37]. He is also an active organizer with UAW 2865, and was recently elected as their unit chair.

Andrés Monroy-Hernández

Andrés Monroy-Hernández is the director of the Princeton HCI group and a faculty member in the Princeton Computer Science department. His team is developing a decentralized worker-centric food delivery protocol in collaboration with restaurant cooperatives, and building the Workers' Algorithm Observatory, a suite of tools to enable worker collectives to gather and analyze their data from gig work platforms.

Vera Khovanskaya

Vera Khovanskaya is a postdoctoral fellow at the University of California, San Diego, where she is a member of the Just Transitions Initiative and the Design Lab. Her research examines the impacts of data collection in the workplace, the opportunities and challenges of data-driven approaches to worker advocacy, and the barriers to worker-centered and community-driven technology design. She is a member of UAW 5810 and a former grad union organizer.

Sean A. Munson

Sean Munson is an Associate Professor in HCDE at UW. His research has engaged with labor at home, in athletic teams, and in health contexts, and he is currently mentoring So on the workplace accountability project. He hopes that this workshop and resulting community can strengthen this and future research.

Mark Zachry

Mark Zachry is a Professor in HCDE at UW where he directs the Communicative Practices in Virtual Workspaces Lab. His research has addressed the effects of computerization on factory work experiences and more recently in co-working, makerspace, and gig work contexts. He is mentoring Tang on her WTO protest archive research.

Sucheta Ghoshal

Sucheta Ghoshal is an Assistant Professor in HCDE at UW where she directs the research group Inquilab. Ghoshal is interested in uncovering ways in which we can form public means of consciousness, resistance, and accountability against technology-mediated systemic oppression. Ghoshal is currently advising Tang, Andrus, and So in their individual projects on labor-oriented CSCW research.

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